

**Curriculum Subcommittee Meeting**  
**March 14, 2013**  
**7:00**

The meeting of the Subcommittee for Curriculum was called to order by Chairperson Erin DiBenedetto at 7:00 p.m. Members of the Subcommittee in addition to Ms. DiBenedetto include Mr. Skerry and Mrs. Van der Kloot. All three subcommittee members were present. Also in attendance were:

Roy E. Belson- Superintendent  
Beverly Nelson-Deputy Superintendent  
Diane J. Caldwell- Assistant Superintendent  
Kathleen Medaglio- Director of Pupil Services  
Bernadette Ricciardelli- Director of Humanities  
Carolyn Joy- Director of Mathematics and Science  
Nicole Chiesa- Interim Director of English Language Arts  
Kathleen Kay- Principal, Columbus School  
Kevin Andrews- Principal, Brooks School  
Kirk Johnson- Principal, Roberts School  
Paul D'Alleva- Principal, Andrews School  
Anthony Volpe, Director, Curtis-Tufts Alternative High School  
Jody Liu- ELA teacher  
Donna Laskey- McGlynn Elementary School teacher  
David Ambrose- ELA teacher

The meeting began with the salute to the flag. In attendance were the following:

Ms. DiBenedetto welcomed everyone to the meeting as she passed out the agendas. She stated the purpose of the meeting which was to focus on curriculum with specific emphasis on the new ELA and mathematics curriculum which have been put in place this school year and to discuss any specific issues related to curriculum in the different schools and among the different groups of students.

Deputy Superintendent Nelson provided an overview of curriculum development in Medford. She stated that as a result of the Education Reform Act of 1993 curriculum frameworks for all subject areas were written and began to be adopted in 1996 with mathematics being the first. Until 1993 school districts were free to develop their own curricula without any guidance or mandate by the state. Medford had already in place curriculum directors for each subject area since the 1980's who developed curriculum for their departments. She mentioned that Medford began the work of developing curriculum in alignment with the frameworks as soon as they were published and in her role as Director of Curriculum beginning in 1998 the district developed a template for all curriculum areas so that there was consistency among all the documents. This was particularly important for elementary teachers who had to teach all curriculum areas. She emphasized that while in the past the frameworks have been developed in a staggered time frame this is the first time with the 2011 adoption of ELA and mathematics frameworks that districts have had to implement and financially support materials for two major content areas. She also stated that new science frameworks would be coming out soon. She handed out a sheet that listed all the areas for which there are frameworks and the different iterations of many of them with ELA and mathematics having the most versions since the 1990's. Some of the curriculum frameworks such as health and foreign language have not been updated since 1999.

Bernadette Ricciardelli who is overseeing the district's Race To The Top Grant has worked collaboratively with central administration on the framework initiative since implementing the frameworks is one of the district's RTTT projects. She has been working with the ELA and Math directors on developing the new curricula. She stated that both directors have spent countless hours working on the new frameworks. They have worked with teams of teachers in unpacking the standards and developing extensive curriculum documents for all grade levels. The template that has been developed has various sections such as *essential questions*, *student objectives*, *framework alignment*. There is still more work to be done with the development of curriculum units and new curriculum brochures which in the past have been very popular with parents. Our plan is that all curricula will be available online. All curriculum units that have and will be developed adhere to the UBD or Backward Design model which is a nationally renowned format developed by Jay McTighe and Grant Wiggins.

Nicole Chiesa, Interim Director of ELA spoke next. She explained the main changes between the 2011 ELA frameworks and the previous versions. These include a major emphasis on informational text and the expectation that students starting in elementary school are able to write a variety of types of essays including narrative, persuasive and expository. She discussed the work that her team of teachers representing all grade levels have done to date and handed out a sample of the new curriculum template (grade 5). English teachers have also begun writing curriculum units that will be shared among all staff. She discussed the 2 pilots- *Journeys* and *Reading Street* that are currently being piloted by a representative group of elementary teachers in all buildings. A decision will be made this spring so that one of these two programs can be adopted for implementation this fall. If the adoption moves forward there is a need for support with significant funding at budget time. (Estimated \$125,000 for SY 2013-2014 and \$ 125, 000 for SY 2014-2015. Although there are needs at the other grade levels many of the resources are being collected from online sources which are cost effective and updated periodically. The elementary teachers and administrators present spoke about the benefits of these new materials which not only address the new standards but also have supports in place for both the challenged and the advanced students.

Carolyn Joy, Director of Mathematics and Science spoke next. She spoke to the changes in the new mathematics framework which is mainly increased rigor in each grade level, guidance for concepts that must be mastered at each grade level and substantive changes to courses such as Algebra 1 and 2. She also mentioned the new 4 year high school mathematics requirement and the plan to put additional courses in place for grade 12 students. She related a similar curriculum development process as that of ELA with teams of teachers working across grade levels to develop the district template and the grade 5 template for mathematics was handed out. She discussed the pilot *Envisions* which is being tried out by teachers at the Columbus School. She relayed that materials for mathematics are still in a state of flux and she would like to continue the elementary pilot for an additional year perhaps bringing another program to the schools for trial. At the middle school level she is also planning to pilot a new program since the current program CMP does not align with the new curriculum standards. She discussed some of her budget needs as well. Similar to the new ELA materials the mathematics materials have tiered support for the different levels of student ability.

Assistant Superintendent Diane Caldwell discussed consistency in the curriculum across different elementary schools and some of the issues that impact transition to middle and high school for students coming from different schools. Ms. Caldwell stated that there was consistency in the elementary schools in most areas since there were many assessments that were standard for grade levels in each school. In addition to consistent assessment, there was uniformity in the writing and vocabulary development at

programs at the elementary level. Ms. DiBenedetto asked about what would be put in place as benchmarks and safeguards for consistency at the other levels. She was told that the new teacher evaluation tool which required common district assessments for each grade and subject area would address this need at the middle and high school level. New frameworks ensure mastery at each grade level. Ms. Caldwell assured the group that special education uses the same materials as regular education students and the new materials were specifically designed to assist special education and ELL students in mastery of the regular curriculum. She stated that administrators- both building and curriculum based- meet together on a monthly basis in meetings facilitated by her and Deputy Superintendent and that curriculum is a topic at each meeting. Subcommittee members Robert Skerry and Paulette Van der Kloot had questions about equal access to curriculum related to the Vocational and Curtis Tufts Schools. When questioned about the Vocational Students and their access to the regular curriculum the Superintendent stated that the structure of the schedule of the Vocational School at the junior and senior level is not the same as the regular high school due to the shops that are a part of the curriculum at this level. All Subcommittee members were assured however that the teachers of academics are very much an integral part of the different academic departments as they attend all meetings and have the same curriculum materials as the high school students.

Superintendent Belson complemented the directors on the amount of work that had been done to date and the need to support the new curriculum with more than materials. He emphasized the need for additional support staff to make sure that the curriculum is implemented as implementation is the most important aspect of curriculum. Mr. Johnson spoke to the need for additional counseling services for the many students whose emotional needs are compromising their ability to focus on academics. Mr. Volpe discussed how his curriculum aligns with the frameworks and expressed concern about the emotional well being of students at the Curtis-Tufts as a factor in moving academics forward.

The meeting was adjourned by Mrs. DiBenedetto at 9:45 p.m.